

The Career Evidence Working Page

Evidence before adjectives.

WHAT THIS EDITION HELPS YOU DO

Rewrite one résumé bullet so your action, context and result are visible without relying on broad claims.

HOW TO USE THIS PAGE

Read the short explanations, then complete the prompts. Allow 20–30 minutes. You do not need to finish every line perfectly; you need one honest, specific piece of evidence you can use in your résumé, interview or networking conversation.

THE WORKING PRINCIPLE

A strong career claim gives the reader somewhere to look. It names the situation, the choice you made, the work you personally carried and the observable difference that followed.

Start with the claim you want a reader to believe.

Do not begin by rewriting the whole résumé. Choose one sentence that sounds positive but leaves the evidence hidden.

COMMON BROAD CLAIMS

Strategic leader

You led important choices. Which choice, in what context?

Cross-functional collaborator

Which groups disagreed or depended on one another?

Results-oriented

What changed, by how much, and over what period?

Commercially minded

What customer, revenue, cost or risk decision did you influence?

YOUR TURN

Write the broad claim you want to make more credible.

THE READER'S NEXT QUESTION

If a skeptical but fair reader saw only this claim, what would they ask next? Write the question in plain language. For example: "What did you actually change?" or "How do you know it worked?"

Educational guidance only. This working page does not guarantee an interview, offer or outcome.

Find the evidence before you find the wording.

A useful bullet does not require a dramatic achievement. It requires a concrete trace of your work. Look for decisions, deliverables, measures, constraints and changes that another person could recognise.

QUICK EVIDENCE INVENTORY

DECISION

What did you decide, prioritise or change?

SCALE

How large was the team, budget, customer base or operation?

CHANGE

What was different afterward?

DELIVERABLE

What did you build, launch, fix or complete?

CONSTRAINT

What made the situation difficult, urgent or uncertain?

WITNESS

Who could explain or verify the work?

NOTES FROM YOUR CAREER

List two projects, moments or responsibilities connected to the claim you wrote on page 2. Fragments are enough.

Tip: search old planning documents, performance reviews, project updates, dashboards and messages for the nouns and numbers you used at the time.

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Separate the claim from the proof.

The claim describes a quality. The proof describes what that quality looked like in practice. Keep both, but let the proof do more of the work.

THE CLAIM-PROOF TEST

CLAIM

“I am a strategic leader.”

PROOF

“I redirected the launch plan after customer research exposed a retention risk.”

CHECK YOUR CLAIM

Circle the words in your claim that are hard to verify: strategic, excellent, dynamic, successful, innovative, strong, collaborative, commercial, visionary. You do not have to delete them automatically. Ask what concrete sentence should sit beside them.

MAKE THE INVISIBLE VISIBLE

Complete these prompts for your own example.

The reader should understand that I can...

The evidence that makes this believable is...

REMOVE ONE UNSUPPORTED WORD

Which adjective could disappear without reducing the meaning? What evidence should replace it?

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Context tells the reader why the work mattered.

Without context, an action can sound like a task list. Context does not mean a long backstory. It means one short signal about what was changing, at risk, newly required or difficult to coordinate.

CHOOSE ONE CONTEXT SIGNAL

The business was entering a new market.

A customer, cost or delivery risk had appeared.

The team had to move faster with fewer resources.

A system, process or relationship was not scaling.

Different stakeholders wanted incompatible outcomes.

A new requirement changed the definition of success.

YOUR CONTEXT IN ONE SENTENCE

Start with “When...” or “As...” and stop after the situation is clear. Do not explain the entire company.

KEEP IT RELEVANT

A context detail earns its place when it helps the reader understand the decision or result. If it is interesting but does not change the meaning, cut it.

Make your contribution easy to locate.

Use a strong verb, then name the object of the work. “Led” is not wrong, but it needs a clearer object: led a reset, led a negotiation, led a migration, led a decision process.

FROM GENERAL TO SPECIFIC

Managed a team

→ Reorganised a 12-person support team around priority accounts.

Worked cross-functionally

→ Aligned product, sales and finance on a staged launch decision.

Improved operations

→ Removed two approval steps from the weekly fulfilment process.

Drove growth

→ Tested a partner channel and redirected spend toward the higher-converting segment.

WRITE THE ACTION

Complete the sentence with a verb that describes what you personally did. Use “we” only when the shared ownership is important; otherwise show your part.

THE INTERVIEW TEST

Could you explain the action in 30 seconds, including the choice you made and the alternatives you rejected? If not, the wording is probably still too broad.

Results are stronger when they can be checked.

A result may be a number, but it can also be a decision reached, a risk reduced, a capability created, a delay avoided or a process made more reliable. Use the most honest measure available.

RESULT OPTIONS

Performance

revenue, margin, conversion, retention, quality, speed

Reliability

fewer incidents, clearer controls, less rework, faster recovery

Scale

users, regions, teams, budget, volume, accounts

Decision

approved plan, resolved trade-off, aligned stakeholders, funded priority

IF YOU CANNOT SHARE THE NUMBER

Use a bounded or comparative description: “cut the review cycle from several weeks to several days,” “reduced repeat escalations,” or “created a repeatable process used by three teams.” Never invent precision.

YOUR RESULT

What changed afterward? What would a colleague notice?

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Build the bullet in a readable order.

A dependable sequence is: context, action, object, result. You can change the order for rhythm, but the reader should not have to reconstruct the logic.

THE FOUR-PART DRAFT

When *context*, I *action object*, resulting in *result*.

YOUR FIRST DRAFT

TRIM THE DRAFT

KEEP

The decision, the specific action and the result.

CHECK

Could a recruiter understand the role and scale without guessing?

REVISED DRAFT

CUT

Scene-setting, repeated adjectives and internal jargon.

ALIGN

Does the wording match a story you can tell in an interview?

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Be specific without exposing confidential information.

You can demonstrate judgement while protecting a client, employer or colleague. Replace sensitive names with the category, use ranges instead of exact figures where appropriate, and describe the decision or change rather than revealing restricted details.

BEFORE AND AFTER

BEFORE

“Responsible for improving a complex process.”

AFTER

“Mapped the handoffs in a high-volume service process, removed duplicate review and reduced avoidable rework.”

BEFORE

“Built strong relationships with senior stakeholders.”

AFTER

“Created a decision brief that aligned three senior teams on launch scope and sequencing.”

SAFE SPECIFICITY CHECK

Ask yourself: What can I say truthfully? What detail is restricted? What substitute still shows the scale, judgement or outcome?

DO NOT OVER-CORRECT

Confidentiality does not require vagueness. It requires choosing a level of detail that demonstrates your work without disclosing protected information.

Test the bullet like a fair reader.

Read the revised sentence once without explaining it aloud. The bullet is doing its job when the reader can see the situation, your contribution and the difference made.

ONE-MINUTE REVIEW

- | | |
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| ☐ I can identify the situation or business context. | ☐ I can identify the action I personally took. |
| ☐ The object of the action is concrete. | ☐ The result is observable or honestly bounded. |
| ☐ The language is understandable outside my organisation. | ☐ Every claim is defensible in conversation. |

ASK A TRUSTED READER

Show the bullet to someone who does not know the project. Ask only two questions: “What do you think I did?” and “What do you think changed?” Their answer reveals what the sentence makes visible.

THEIR READING

ONE FIX

What will you change after the review?

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Make one piece of evidence travel further.

The finished bullet is not the end product. It is a compact source of truth you can adapt for a résumé, an interview answer, a networking conversation, a performance review or a decision about your next role.

YOUR NEXT THREE USES

RÉSUMÉ

Where will this evidence appear?

CONVERSATION

Who should understand this capability?

THE COMMITMENT

Complete this sentence and put a date beside it: “Before my next application, interview or career conversation, I will...”

INTERVIEW

Which question could this story answer?

NEXT EVIDENCE

What adjacent example should you document next?

KEEP THE RECORD

Save the final bullet with the source notes behind it: project, date, scope, result and who can verify it. This makes future tailoring faster and keeps your claims consistent.

Framework note: The context–action–result sequence is compatible with the STAR approach used in behavioural interview preparation. See [MIT Career Advising & Professional Development](#), “[The STAR Method for Behavioral Interviews](#)”.

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